THEATRE

A Musical Marriage

Faezeh Jalali has returned to the Prithvi Theatre Festival with **Runaway Brides**, *a hilarious musical about Indian weddings*



MILIND SHELTE

Faezeh Jalali loves to fill up the stage with a big acting ensemble. In her latest production, *Runaway Brides*, which premiered at the Prithvi Theatre Festival, the multi-hyphenate theatrewallah does exactly that, but she takes a filmi route. The backdrop is a wedding and there's chaos, and plenty of scandal, when the groom and bride's mothers run off; there's also a Barjatya-like *antakshri* which lends itself to many Hindi film songs. But despite the tropes, you know it's a Jalali work with the humour and progressive social takes woven in. The play has an interfaith couple, lesbian lovers and a wedding vigilante struggling to disrupt the proceedings. "I have always thought that theatre is where you should be able to say what you need to say. Since such few people are watching it, less people are offended," says Jalali who had just wrapped up a rehearsal in a black box studio in Mumbai.

"Earlier, I wouldn't think of what's offensive and what's not, now I do. But I don't do anything to offend, it's more to make a point, to look at ourselves as these people, recognise the stereotype, laugh at it, and also correct." A theatre veteran of nearly two decades, Jalali is known for the physicality in her works given her training in clowning, aerial acrobats and kalaripayattu. After over a decade working with different theatre groups, she started Fats TheArts in 2009, knowing that she wanted to focus more on writing and directing originals than adapting works. "Why are we doing so many British and American plays? You sit in the audience and you aren't feeling it," she says. "I don't know if I want to do another Shakespeare. It's great to learn and you never say never to adapting it but I feel new stories is the way to go." It helps that she's an actor and "writes like one" and often incorporates both music and movement into her narratives.

RUNAWAY BRIDES premieres at the Prithvi Theatre Festival in Mumbai, on till Nov. 18

Runaway Brides may have a sense of familiarity, given that it taps into most Indian families' favourite obsession—weddings. "They are places of high conflict," she says. "Sometimes people's lives are built around it, but the wedding day ends up being horrible because you are stressed and exhausted. I feel your worst side comes out." Jalali plays to the gallery but not without adding her own spin. "I feel heteronormative stories are all around us. At *shaadis*, other couplings do happen, but these are not hook-ups you expect." The play marks the second work she's showcased at the Prithvi festival—the earlier being *Bone of Contention* (2019). More than a badge of honour, she sees performing here as an opportunity for "a hungry theatreperson" to showcase work. "There's so much I want to do," she says. Luckily, audiences are fascinated with her farcical (mis)adventures too. ■

–Suhani Singh